

Does the claim that God exists outside of time give us
reason to reject premise (2) of the foreknowledge
argument?

It does look like, if Aquinas' view is right, (2) is false. That
is good for the defender of free will.

We'll shortly consider some ways of responding to Edwards' argument. But first let's think about how Edwards' argument might be related to an argument for fatalism.

Suppose that someone did not believe in God — and hence rejected premise (2) of Edwards' argument — but did believe that there were truths about all of our future actions. Could they give an argument similar to Edwards' argument?

There are truths
about our future
actions.

In the past, God
had
foreknowledge of
our future
actions.

To get a grip on this, imagine that one learned of another universe, which had its own system of time and space. And suppose one was given all of the information about everything that ever happens in that universe, and the time at which it happens. So, in particular, you know everything about every free action in that universe. But it's not like you knew of every action **before** that action occurred — you don't exist in the time of that universe.

Let's look again at the premises which make
reference to time.

1. We have no choice about past facts.
2. In the past, God had foreknowledge of our future actions.
3. We have no choice about the fact that God knows that in the future I will perform a certain action. (1,2)

We started off with two arguments for the reality of fate.

The first was the Logical Argument for Fate, which was based on the Law of the Excluded Middle.

The law of the excluded middle

For any proposition P , either P is true or $\text{Not-}P$ is true.

But what if we denied this? Perhaps claims about future free actions — like claims about what you will eat for dinner tonight — are neither true nor false, but simply “undetermined.” They do not now have any truth-value (though they will later).

Here's a challenge to this kind of view. Suppose that you say to a friend, 'I bet Mariana is going to decide to major in philosophy.' And then suppose that, a month later, after long (free) deliberations, Mariana does indeed make the obviously correct choice and decides to major in philosophy. We would be inclined to say: 'What you said about Mariana **was** true.'

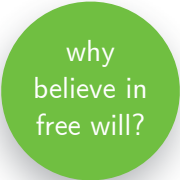
Doesn't this imply that there was already a truth about what Mariana was going to decide, back when you made the prediction?



two
arguments
against free
will



is fate
real?



why
believe in
free will?



three
ways out

Could we say that neither of these are true (or false), but that
both simply lack truth-value?

You will get married
on July 1, 2030.

You will not get married
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God knows that in the future I will

3. We have not checked that

2. In the past, God had foreknowledge of

performance: (1, 2)

1. We have no choice about past facts.



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prediction?

So now consider a possible scenario in which someone exactly like you would get

never had any. So they lacked free will before getting a Predicto.

that Predict did not **take away** their free will; it just shows them that they

a Predictor. By the above line of thought, this person would lack free will. But

But this person was stipulated to be exactly like you. So you don't have free will,

either.

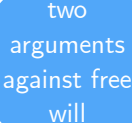
things as fate, then there is no free will.

and the example of the Predictor — which seem to show that if there is such a

So far we've looked at two imaginary thought experiments—the story of Osmo,

serious challenge to the reality of free will?

Our question is: do either fatigue or foreknowledge pose a



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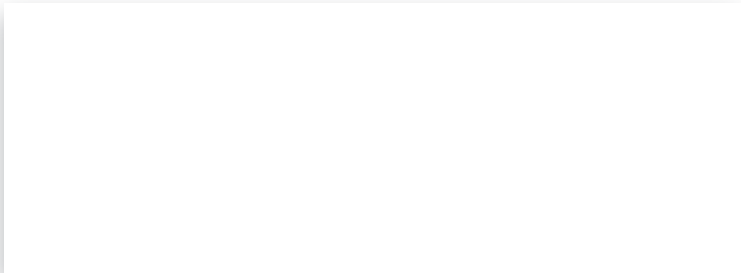
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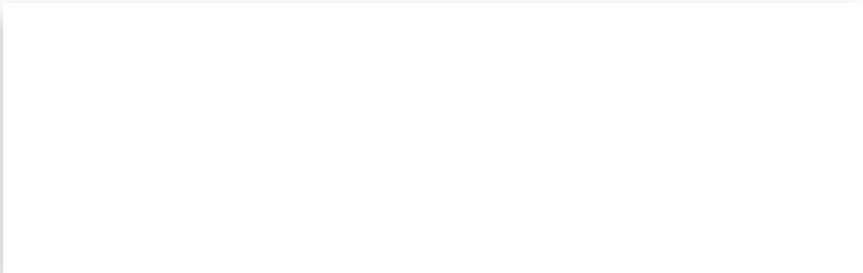
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Our first topic today is the oldest challenge to the existence of free will: the challenge to

freedom that comes from fate.

God only shows up in premises (2) and

replace reference to God's foreknowledge

(5) Let's look at what happens if we

our future actions.

with reference to the being of truth about



perform a certain action (1,2)

1. We have no direct facts.

3 We have not at the fact that



2*In the past, there were truths about

4. If we have no choice about p , and no

all of our activities.

God knows that in the future I will

then we have the choice about q.

acaioid.

0 We have achieved what we

choice about the fact that if p , then q ,

will perform various actions.

some action, then I will prefer that

(3, 4, 5)

that if it is true that I will perform

5* We have noticed that the fact

The fatalist argument

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